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Buddy DeFranco

Buddy DeFranco almost singlehandedly brought the clarinet into modern jazz. He was born in Camden, New Jersey in 1923 and made his reputation with the swing bands of Tommy Dorsey and Charlie Barnet. Buddy was a member of Count Basie's small band in the early '50s and soon after embraced the new style of jazz pioneered by Charlie Parker and Dizzy Gillespie. His abundant technique and inventive soloing kept him in the forefront of the jazz scene and he recorded frequently with artists of equal caliber. Buddy was one of the first jazz artists to move into the schools with improvisation workshops and is currently working on a new method book for clarinet.

Buddy was interviewed at the Sarasota Jazz Festival on April 13, 1996 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive and it's a great pleasure to have with us master clarinetist Buddy DeFranco, who just described his instrument as an "agony pipe."

BD: I got that from my sister Maryanne. Maryanne always called it an agony pipe. She says that's what it sounded like when I was practicing. And she was right. It's the strangest instrument.

MR: Difficult. One of the more difficult instruments I think.

BD: Difficult, and I would say in line with the bassoon, oboe, French horn and harp. It's in that category. It's agonizing. You must squeak on a clarinet for years before you begin to play anything.

MR: And it strikes me like a violin in that there is no such thing as a mediocre violin or clarinet. It's either you're really good or if it's mediocre it's awful.

BD: It's pretty bad. We've got a problem though in jazz, of too many mediocre clarinet players who insist on playing.

MR: Yeah. Well they figure I can play sax, I can play clarinet. Well you've had quite an interesting career and we want to talk about some of the things you've done. Didn't you start out winning a contest?

BD: Monk, I did, yes. I was fourteen, and won the Tommy Dorsey Swing Contest. And Tommy had this national broadcast from the major cities on a Saturday night. Every week he'd be in a different city. It had four contestants, and it was the Tommy Dorsey Swing Contest. And I was pitted against three other guys, we were the four finalists. Let's see we had a cadet who played trumpet, and a vibraharp player who was quite good, and someone else I forget — oh a trombone player I'm pretty sure. But I was in line, and I was fourteen and I wanted to win of course, and my teacher, Willy DeSimone at the time, played in the pit in the theater, in the Earle Theater in Philadelphia, which is where they

held the broadcast. They had the broadcast and the contest. And Willie was determined that I would win. So he said, "For the contest you will wear short pants, because the people love that. You'll look so young, and the clarinet will look real big." And I was very skinny at the time. And then he showed me a trick with the clarinet, it's really almost common with old time clarinet players, to hold the clarinet like this with one hand and play a note. And he said, "At the end of your solos," he said, "you're going to play 'Honeysuckle Rose' because everybody knows the song, and at the end of the solo play your E like that and put out this hand so the people know that you're playing with one hand, you know the people can see it. And he was in the pit and I was scared to death, but I was playing and I watched him signal — one hand — and I did. Well those other guys had no chance you know. They had to lose, no matter how good they played, you know.

MR: You were set up.

BD: I was set up, yes. But Tommy liked it. But he saw something in my playing, he really did. What it was I don't know, but he did. He said, "Stick around kid, someday you're going to play in my band."

MR: And that's what happened, right?

BD: That's what happened. In fact, many years later, I don't know how many, ten, fifteen years later I auditioned for his band and got in.

MR: Did you grow up listening to the kind of music that you eventually played? Radio? No?

BD: No. We started, my grandfather was an opera buff and liked classical music, symphonic music, and that's what we listened to first and that's what I played first. And I was fairly good at it and played in a junior symphony in Philadelphia and Symphony Club in Philadelphia, as I was twelve, eight, eight to twelve years old playing in that. And then I took a music course at the vocational school, Mastbaum in Philadelphia. In fact Joe Wilder was here with us — Joe Wilder? He and I were in the same class together back in Philadelphia. We had a great time and we learned. They had two really dedicated teachers. One in particular, Mr. Lavenneu, conducted the orchestra. I think he was, well he was the 1936 version or 1937 version of Mr. Holland. That's him. Except maybe more severe and more intimidating. But we accepted that. Now it seems like band directors and orchestra conductors can't get away with being so volatile. They have to be careful, they'll get sued or something like that. But in those days if he heard, you know if he knew that the third trumpet player or the second string violin, if they were playing wrong notes, he'd throw the baton in that direction. But we loved him, we loved him. We knew that he knew and he was directing us in the right way.

MR: Yeah. He cared enough to get angry I guess.

BD: Yeah. He cared enough to get angry. And so that was a great experience. Then I heard Benny Goodman. Oh I heard Johnny Mince first. He played with Tommy Dorsey's band.

And my brother and I would go to the Earle Theater in Philadelphia and sit there all day on a Saturday, five, six shows, and see every show. And I watched Johnny Mince play with Tommy Dorsey and I thought I'd really like to do that, play jazz. And then of course Benny Goodman, and then Benny Goodman was, I would say responsible for putting the jazz clarinet on the map. Then Artie Shaw. And Artie Shaw to me was, he might still be my favorite today. So one thing led to another and I wanted to play jazz. I told my grandfather who flipped out, "crazy." Although he began to like Benny Goodman. In fact I used to tell Count Basie this story all the time. Basie loved — no matter how many times I'd tell Bill the story, he loved it. I'd come home from a long trip with one of the bands — Johnny "Scat" Davis or Gene Krupa's band or Charlie Barnet. And my grandfather would greet me at the door and he'd say in Italian dialect, in an Italian accent, "Okay Biga shota" Biga shota he called me. "You're looking pretty good — I seen your picture in the paper — what do you got in the pocket?"

MR: Did you have anything?

BD: No. He says, "You hear Benny Goodaman? What do you do?" He loved Benny Goodman. And Bill Basie would flip every time I'd tell him that story.

MR: What was it like being on the roads with those bands?

BD: I think an invaluable experience, just great to be on the road. Even at that early age we appreciated that. We liked the idea of being involved in that kind of music and swing music and playing, and the discipline of playing in a band was unequaled. Also you experience life in different ways and you get to meet different people and some of those bands like Johnnie "Scat" Davis or Gene Krupa, Charlie Barnet, they both had some of the finest players. All three of them had some of the finest players, who later became excellent studio players or first or second chair in a big bands, some in symphonies. And it was a great experience because you would meet the young fellows who were coming up, and all fired up, and you'd meet some of the older guys, experienced, and they could teach you a lot. And then that gray middle section of boozers and dopers that were really on their way out but still could play fairly well but you knew they were sinking, which was a great lesson because we knew to avoid that gray area, as young people. Well most of us anyway, not all of us. Stay away from that and try for that top guy, you know try to be like him.

MR: So the first couple of bands, Krupa—

BD: Scat Davis, Krupa, Charlie Barnet, Ted Fio Rito, and Boyd Raeburn. I don't know if you ever heard Boyd Raeburn.

MR: I've heard of him.

BD: It was really the first outside band, the first space music band. Most songs were totally unrecognizable with those arrangements. We loved it and it was a great experience, it was

like going to school to play these arrangements. We had George Handy arrangements, Johnny Richards. In fact the young fellow that was singing, Jay Johnson, used to announce the band, the Rayburn band, backstage. And he'd say, "From the Planet Mars, here's Boyd Rayburn." And it was like that. And I tell my audience every time, that band was so far out we could empty a room in two minutes. We did. Nobody liked it.

MR: How long did it last?

BD: It lasted about a year and a half.

MR: Yeah.

BD: Well he made a lot of noise in inner circles, you know music circles.

MR: Yeah. Would they book you for a dance though?

BD: Unfortunately they booked the band for dances too as well because you had to fill in. In those days you couldn't consistently play concerts. So it had to be dances as well.

MR: They danced out of the room, right?

BD: Danced out of the room.

MR: What was it like, did you notice different responses in different parts of the country?

BD: No actually the amazing thing about swing and big bands was it was accepted, generally, in every area of the country. And even some areas where, you know, Dubuque, Iowa — you'd say Dubuque, Iowa, why? You'd play there, five thousand people or whatever, all jumping up and down, and five hundred in front of the stage just listening and the rest all dancing. Just incredible. In Dorsey's band for instance, every guy in the band had his fan club. And we played some stadiums, and it was so jammed with people that you just couldn't get off during intermission, they'd have to pass up the Cokes and water up to the band from the police, and the police would do that. They would just be so tightly wound around the bandstand. Couldn't get off.

MR: It was the pop music of the day.

BD: It was the pop music of the day and also a lot of people wondered why jazz didn't stay in that focal point, in that high area. When we started playing bebop, I say "we" because I was a part of the Bebop Era. And of course I heard Charlie Parker and that was it, I had to be a part of that. And rhythmically it was a little different and harmonically, and so we divorced seventy or eighty percent of the dancers. They could not dance to bebop. They could dance to straight swing music, that was jitterbug. But when we got to complex rhythms and all that, they couldn't, their brains couldn't handle the intellectual development of bebop and their feet couldn't handle the thematic development, so they reverted to Neanderthal. They had to.

MR: They found something else.

BD: They found something else. They had to go back in history and find the simple way to do it. So we lost out that way. That's part of it anyway.

MR: Your first experience in bebop, where did that take place? Back in New York?

BD: Yeah. Back in New York. I had not worked with Charlie Shavers at the time but we knew Charlie pretty well and met him on Broadway. When I say "we," Dodo Marmarosa, who was quite a piano player. I would say at fourteen years old he was one of the best in the world, jazz piano player, who also recorded with Bird and was on all of the bands that I've played with including Tommy Dorsey. He was with Artie Shaw as well. Dodo Marmarosa. Artie loved his playing. But he and I ran into Charlie Shavers. And Charlie Shavers said, "There's some guy up in Harlem that I heard last week playing alto." He said "I don't know what he's playing, but it's completely different and it's pretty wild stuff. You ought to hear it." So we made it our business to go and hear Bird when we found out where he was going to be up in Harlem, which was I think Minton's at the time. And when we saw him he had borrowed a saxophone, he didn't even own a saxophone at the time. But I am proud to say from that time on I said I've got to try to learn to articulate on the clarinet like he does on the alto. I was one of the first and I'm very proud of it. And then just a short while after, Dodo Marmarosa said, "Why don't you play clarinet like Charlie Parker?" So I did. I did. And I was really the first, successfully the first bebop clarinet player in the business. All the guys were gravitating toward that but I was the first.

MR: It takes an awful lot of facility to pull that off.

BD: Yes indeed it takes a lot of facility. And I was lucky because I had all that early, excellent training so I could do that. And Charlie Parker and Art Tatum to me are the two that stand out for genius in this business. Absolute genius. Everyone else, as good as they are — and this includes Oscar, and Oscar will tell you this, Oscar to me was the epitome of pianists — would tell you that the first, one of the innovators was Art Tatum. Nobody played like him before that. But after that everybody tried. Charlie Parker was the same. Charlie Parker influenced every musician in the world that plays jazz. From his point on, even now, we all live in Charlie Parker's shadow.

MR: Someone had a quote about that. If he could sue people for what they've taken from him.

BD: From what we've all taken — we had to. And what the strangest thing is is that some of the most commercial type bands, we used to call them "Mickey Mouse bands" and even the rock groups, unconsciously are playing a lot of those figures that Bird originated, and are not even aware of it. And you can go to Bapooh Japan and see a little guy get up and play tenor, and he's maybe ten years old and he's playing bebop. You know he's playing Charlie Parker oriented music.

MR: What did the record companies, what did they think of bebop?

BD: Most of them didn't like it. They didn't understand it or they didn't like it. It's only when bebop caught on with Dizzy and Bird and Jazz at the Philharmonic that record companies

began to say well maybe there's something there. Norman Granz had his own record companies and began selling records like mad. And so they got in on that. But most of the company executives, in almost any area, didn't know what they were recording. I hate to say that, but it's pretty close to the truth. Very few. Very few really knew, good or bad.

MR: What to market and what not to market.

BD: Yes, exactly. What to market and what not to market. Yup. That's really what it amounts to. The amazing thing about that era was that even though — it never died — it just kind of faded and then other music came in. Even though it faded, it never lost hold. It was always there, always consistent, we always had a loyal following around the world. A very loyal following. True a narrow corridor, a narrow section of the public, but very loyal, and always came to see us.

MR: There wasn't that much room but if you were at the top of your game, then maybe you could get enough chances to play.

BD: Yeah. And even when things were really fading here for bebop so to speak, or modern jazz, we could go to Europe, and we're always recognized in Europe. Seventy percent of my income was in Europe for many years. 1950 around that area is when I decided I wanted a big band, but Willard Alexander came to me and said, "I'm putting together a small group for Count Basie because big bands are kind of folding." Which I didn't want to believe. I wanted my big band because I idolized Benny Goodman and Artie Shaw. But he was right. So he put me with the Basie Band in 1950 and the guy I told you about, Lenny Lewis, he was managing, he was the manager.

MR: No kidding?

BD: Yeah.

MR: So this was in Chicago, when they got together?

BD: It was at the Brass Rail in Chicago, yeah.

MR: Seven — six or seven pieces?

BD: It started out Clark Terry and Bobby Graf from St. Louis, a tenor player, myself on front line, Bill Basie and Jimmy Lewis played bass and Gus Johnson played drums. And shortly after that, Freddie Green joined and that was fantastic. It really made that group.

MR: You had to have Freddie, right?

BD: Huh?

MR: I mean Freddie was such a part of —

BD: He was a part of Basie, and Freddie came by a couple of times and just sat in because he wanted to play, and Bill realized as well, this is the rhythm section. It was great to work with them. It was like going to swing school. And then Bobby Graf left shortly after we organized and Wardell Gray. And he was great, he was just great. He was a great player. So that was quite a group. That quintet was quite a group, sextet. And on Sunday

afternoon, a young fellow by the name of Joe Williams would come and sit in and sing, because he loved Bill Basie. And after the second time that Joe came in and sang, you'd see Bill's eyes light up, this is the guy that can sing today. It wasn't long, then he hired Joe.

MR: What kind of material was Joe doing at that time?

BD: Well he was doing mostly the swing era stuff and the blues. Because he had followed Jimmy Rushing, who was really the blues singer of the big band era, the top guy in fact. But of course Joe Williams had that little extra something that added to his performance with Basie, the sound and robust voice he had, plus the fact that he could handle the ballads very well. So that made him an extra feature. And that was great, I enjoyed that.

MR: And how long did that group hang together?

BD: Hard to figure. I would say about a year and a half or so. Basie found Lenny Lewis stealing and fired him. I found out also that Artie Shaw chased — before all this happened Artie Shaw chased Lenny Lewis down Broadway one time for some odd reason. But he was brilliant. I can't put him down. Lenny Lewis was brilliant.

MR: A good promoter.

BD: A good promoter, and Basie will tell you the same thing. I'll tell you working with Count Basie was like, we were a family, it was actually a family. As loyal as a family, maybe more so. And it was one of the happiest experiences of my whole career. For instance, playing with Tommy Dorsey was a great experience. But that was almost a terrorizing experience in many ways, because Tommy was bigger than life and he could fire you at a drop of a hat you know. He was generous, he was, and I'll quote Zoot Sims, you may have heard it, Tommy Dorsey was a great bunch of guys. So he was all those things. But Bill Basie was one of the nicest people in the whole world. And it reflected in the group, in the way we got along.

MR: Was there ever a problem with the racial mix in that group?

BD: Not in the group. Never —

MR: Not in the group but —

BD: Well yeah. We used to consider the people on the outside who had problems with the race combination "civilian." We did have some problems, and then I got in some difficulty in Chicago because while I was with Basie's band I stayed at the Croydon Hotel, I always stayed there. And Harry Belafonte, we worked together a lot opposite each other. He would come over and stay at my place for overnight or two days if they had room there. And then I began to receive phone calls from anonymous people, "we don't want him around here — no blacks around here" —you know. At one time I was accosted almost by a group of guys in Chicago for playing with black people. But in the Basie band, it was never a consideration. And I loved Bill for that reason. Bill Basie

looked at you as a player. And a human being. And that was it. It's a strange thing too, I almost during that time became, with some of the experiences with the civilians on the outside I almost became anti-white. Yeah. And with good reason, you know, at the time.

MR: I mean the music you were playing, it was so connected with black culture and there you were in the middle of it.

BD: That's right. And half, maybe more than half of jazz, was created by white people. And Dizzy spelled it out pretty well, we had — utilizing African and Latin rhythms and Caucasian and Asian harmonies, and put that together and play jazz. So that was you know a conscious effort to work together, and it worked. So there was no room for a differences of races. Once in a while you might experience that in the music business but rarely, rarely in the jazz field, in those days. It changed you know. But in those days it was either you played or you didn't play.

MR: So shortly after that group, Basie was able to, economically I guess, add his people back.

BD: There again, Willard Alexander said the time now is right for the big band and I think Bill Basie is the kind of a guy that could spearhead this kind of thing, and he knew he had Joe Williams with Basie's band, who was a plus factor, not only musically but commercially. And he said to Bill Basie, "Time for the big band." And everybody in the business, including Norman Granz, said better not take a chance, you know. Big bands are finished. But Willard said no, let's go ahead, let's go ahead. And they did and they soon made a couple of records and they made one "Every Day" with Joe Williams, and that was a smash. Big, big hit. So it catapulted Basie right up to the top again. And it also brought the idea of big bands back into focus and as a result of that, and guys like Woody Herman and Stan Kenton, some others that kept on operating, they've instigated perhaps more than thirty thousand big bands that are operating now in schools. Which nobody knows about, but that's a lot of people. That's a lot of bands.

MR: You got into some jazz education early on.

BD: Oh yeah. I still am, well with a recommendation from Stan Kenton. Things were very rough and I wasn't doing too well and I was griping and moaning at Stan, and Stan says "well that's true, things are bad, why don't you do what I do? Let's get into the schools and try to salvage something from the young people in the schools. We know we're not going to do much good with the older people, but let's get in the schools and get the young people and see what we can do." And I did. I started going, teaching and doing these clinics and master class sessions in schools, which also instigated a lot of interest in not only bands, but the clarinet. Yeah. Because the clarinet really almost died as a jazz instrument. But we kept it going.

MR: Did a good job too. I mean it's still happening now.

BD: Oh I think there are more clarinet players now then there have been in twenty years, which is great.

MR: And for a few years you were leading the Glenn Miller Orchestra?

BD: I did for eight years. '66 to '74.

MR: I saw you in Rochester, New York.

BD: Did you really?

MR: I think it was '66.

BD: We had a good band. In fact, in fact, in fact, last week we received a CD that's just released in Japan of the band, actually the last group that I led, the last Miller band. We recorded in Japan. It's taken twenty-four years to release that record. But we got a copy of the CD and it's a great CD and the band is just terrific. And you could hear that youth and fire in that band. Yeah. So we proved something there also. When I say "we" we kept the idea of that big band and swing going. And it turns out the Glenn Miller Band is probably the most popular band in the world. That includes Japan. Number one band there, the Glenn Miller Orchestra.

MR: In Japan.

BD: Yeah.

MR: Boy that's saying something.

BD: And he was remarkable. Because it seemed like he really knew how to turn out hit records. He did. One after another. I can't think of any other band that has as many hit recordings as Glenn Miller.

MR: I guess it took him a while to find his sound but once he found it he really took it and ran with it.

BD: Well actually it didn't take him that long. I would go through the annals and the files of the Glenn Miller offices, and the archives, and I'd read scores of Glenn. Actually "Moonlight Serenade" was not "Moonlight Serenade" when he wrote it. He wrote it, he called it "Glenn's Theme" and he wrote it as a graduation piece for Schillinger orchestration method and that was it. It was that lead clarinet with the saxes. And according to Dave Mackey, who was the executor for the Glenn Miller estate, he tried to sell that sound to Ray Noble, I don't know if you've heard of Ray Noble, big band popular? And Ray Noble told him, not good, will never make it. But he just kept it until he got his own band, and he made it.

MR: We should pair that guy with the people who turned down the Beatles I guess.

BD: Well not many people did. Or Madonna. I think it all has its place in the scheme of things as long as it's not for instance, here I go again, I don't want to get up on the soapbox too much, but since I have the cameras —

MR: It's the time to do it.

BD: It is the time to do it. A guy or a girl gets to be a big star, movies or other. Big star, big, big, big, big. All of a sudden, every word that that person utters, politically, religiously, whatever, is the word. They are an authority on everything that happens. And I found out that's really not true at all. I found out also that great talent in music has nothing to do with intelligence. It's another part of the brain that's operating. But whoever gets really, really big and popular, they're the ones who become the guru or whatever, and people accept everything they say. It's really too bad they shouldn't. It really shouldn't be that way you see? But there's a place for everything. So therefore, back to my original premise — you may not be a good musician, but you are an entertainer, and you have the charisma. That's it. Don't label this person a musical genius. All right?

MR: Because we know there's only two of them now. There was Parker and Tatum, right?

BD: Well I think there might have been more, and you know, Peterson, Oscar Peterson is in that area, John Coltrane, Chick Corea and today Cecil Taylor I think. Cecil Taylor is probably the ultimate jazz creator today, the ultimate in modern jazz, modern jazz. Not commercial I don't think.

MR: No. I wouldn't book him for a dance. But this must have been a fun record to make.

BD: Oh, yeah, this is great.

MR: Oscar Peterson.

BD: This is funny because Norman decided that since so much time had passed, he decided to title this "Buddy DeFranco meets the Oscar Peterson Quartet." When we actually met in the 50s and played together at the Jazz at the Philharmonic. Night after night. And recorded several albums before together, including one of my favorites, the "George Gershwin Songbook." Russ Garcia arrangements, the big orchestra, that's one of the nicest. But this was fun. It's always fun to work with Oscar. Always. Because he's so dynamic and has impeccable taste in music I think. He knows when to play what. Probably the most, probably one of my favorite pianists to work with, because he knows how to play for the clarinet especially.

MR: Interesting statement. How to play for the clarinet.

BD: There's a certain way, certain registers of the instrument, the piano, that you can utilize behind a clarinet that makes it sing or brings it out, and Oscar is number one in that area, as opposed to say, I love, as I told you Art Tatum was one of the original geniuses of jazz, like Louis Armstrong, like Bix Beiderbecke. But very difficult to play with. And he did not enhance the clarinet, Art Tatum. He was really on his own and you played your clarinet to suit him. It was his ball game, as opposed to Oscar, who really made you sound good.

MR: That's very interesting. What is in the future for you?

BD: More of the same. Festivals and concerts and clinics in schools, and I wrote, I recently finished a book, I got a bright idea, I think it's bright and I've managed to get it through the copyright office, and I transcribed 20 of the Hanon piano exercises for the clarinet. But I transcribed them in all keys, all twelve keys. Which was remarkable. I'm working on being able to play them now, but it's great, it's great. And we plan to put that book out very soon. And I did a thing with Rob Pronk, a thing, I did four radio shows with Rob Pronk, and with Hilverson, with a big orchestra. He wrote the charts and Van Overloop conducted, and some of the most beautiful arrangements ever, and we're going to release those here as an LP, as a CD rather.

MR: Are you working with any particular record label right now?

BD: Not right now. The last one was "Chip Off the Old Block" that I did for Concord. Carl Jefferson suggested I do another album pretty soon, unfortunately Carl is gone, so I don't know, that's in limbo. I did an album recently with Al Raymond's band, a big band in Philadelphia, some nice stuff in there. I've done a lot of recording activities. Many re-issues as well as what I've done recently. Many re-issues.

MR: It sounds healthy.

BD: Very healthy and I keep practicing and try to make it less an agony pipe, and I'll never forget Horowitz I believe it was, they said, "You're 82 years old and you're still practicing?" And he said, "I think I'm getting better."

MR: You know we don't usually ask technical questions, but we may have a few clarinet players who might ask you about your instrument and the odd looking barrel—

BD: The odd looking barrel? Well let's see from top to bottom this is my creation, this mouthpiece and it's put out by Bari, they release it, Bari mouthpieces.

MR: Bari?

BD: B-A-R-I? Yeah.

MR: I play their reeds.

BD: Yeah, right. They put out the BDF mouthpiece. John Denman, by the way, John Denman makes excellent clarinet reeds, he's in Tucson, a fine clarinet player. Bob Wiban ligature, from Kansas, and this is a Accubore barrel, which is made of metal, not wood, so that it doesn't change so much from different areas and climates. And it's a Yamaha clarinet, and I've played Yamaha clarinets, what 24 years. This is about the best system I've worked out to play what I do in modern jazz.

MR: The least agony.

BD: Yeah you always try to get away from the agony. Well I'll tell you those Hanon exercises will teach you about agony.

MR: Can you swing 'em too?

BD: Well you actually can. I think unconsciously that's why I chose them because they can lend themselves to lines that you would play in jazz.

MR: And tomorrow, you're playing in the Kansas City group.

BD: Yeah. That's named I guess because it would simulate the Count Basie small group, and Clark Terry is on that thing and Clark and I go way back. We were really buddies. He was one fast story about Clark and myself because Clark and I were contemporaries in 1950 when we joined Basie's band, and the first rehearsal I will never forget because Clark and I had abundant technique on our instruments, both of us. And we both wanted to show off. So we did. Practically the first song we played, we played everything we could imagine into the first song, and enough for three symphonies. And Bill Basie stopped us. He says, "Well wait a minute, we're going to get there, honest, we're going to get there. Take it easy. Not too many notes." And he started plunking at the piano the way he does. And before you know we got the idea. There it is. There's the tempo, there's the feeling. Yeah. Of course Clark got it a little faster than I did I would say, because I was always a show off you know, technique, I wanted to show everybody. But it was a good lesson, right in the first rehearsal, a good one.

MR: Yeah. Because that's what his music was about was the feel of it and how to play inside that.

BD: And I never realized how everything we played emanated from Bill at the keyboard. And if you isolate everything else and listen to the way he engineered every chart, every arrangement, there was certain ways to play chords and cues and figures. It was just marvelous the way he did it. He knew how to bring a soloist in. How to bring a big band in to the last chorus, everything. And when he and Freddie Green got together, all you had to do was zero in on those two guys.

MR: We've asked a number of people, what made the Basie rhythm section what it was. And they agree with you.

BD: Absolutely. Without a doubt.

MR: And Joe, I've read about Joe, he would talk about hearing his cues from Basie. When he heard Basie play something, he knew he had eight bars or twelve bars to get up there.

BD: Basie had a cue for everything. He even had to cue for the audience, a feeling for what they wanted at that time. So he had a little cues we finally picked up on. And he even had a little cue for good looking girls that came in. That was Bill.

MR: Well this has really been fascinating talking with you.

BD: Thank you. Thank you.

MR: And as our leading exponent of the jazz clarinet, I hope that you keep it up forever.

BD: Thank you. I'm going to try because I think I'm improving.

MR: Well on behalf of Hamilton College I'd like to thank Buddy DeFranco so much for joining us today. I wish you a good concert tonight.

BD: Thank you. My pleasure.